Textual Practice

ISSN: 0950-236X (Print) 1470-1308 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rtpr20

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To cite this article: Jeffrey Mather (22 Jan 2026): Slow comics: resource extraction in graphic narrative, Textual Practice, DOI: 10.1080/0950236X.2025.2608014

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2608014

Published online: 22 Jan 2026.

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TEXTUAL PRACTICE
https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2608014

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Slow comics: resource extraction in graphic narrative

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ABSTRACT
This essay investigates how comics, through their capacity for 'slowness,' can challenge readers to reflect on the far-reaching effects of resource extraction in a globalised world. Focusing on Joe Sacco's *Paying the Land* (2020) and Kate Beaton's *Ducks: Two Years in the Oil Sands* (2022), both set in Canada, I analyze how comics' formal properties represent the disruptive effects of extractive practices such as mining, forestry, and fracking. These works reveal how extraction reshapes landscapes, fragments ecological and social rhythms, and imposes alienating temporal regimes. At the same time, they engage readers in a 'slow' mode of reading, foregrounding the in/visibility of extraction and inviting reflection on our own ethical and emotional entanglement in extractive economies. In my discussion of Sacco's and Beaton's texts, slowness is approached as a formal and narrative technique that decelerates and intensifies reader engagement, critiques temporal disruption, and foregrounds reflexive and embodied inquiry.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 21 January 2025; Accepted 3 September 2025

KEYWORDS Graphic narrative; extractivism; energy humanities; slow narrative

The ways that resource extraction fragments, accelerates, and disrupts time have become a central concern in critical theory, highlighting how such processes reshape visibility and narrative form. Scholars have demonstrated that extractivism operates not only as a set of industrial practices, but as a pervasive mode of organising life and generating global circuits of power and dependency.[1] For the environmental critic Rob Nixon, resource-intensive extractivism, and the resulting chains of environmental harm, are discussed in terms of 'slow violence,' a term used to address the way that environmental damage is gradually, and unspectacularly, manifest in ways that are not always immediately or easily discerned as part of a single narrative. For Nixon, slow violence often eludes public attention precisely because it lacks the spectacle demanded by an age of instant gratification; it is a

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'violence that occurs gradually and out of sight, a violence of delayed destruction that is dispersed across time and space'.[2]

This essay argues that comics offer a uniquely effective medium for confronting the dispersed, invisible disruptions of slow violence. Comics not only make visible what is typically hidden and manipulate time and sequence to mirror the uneven tempos of harm; the form also invites slow, participatory, and affective engagement – helping readers not just to see, but to feel and think with the slow violence that shapes our world. Foundational work in comics studies has emphasised the participatory and self-reflexive nature of reading comics. Thierry Groensteen's 'iconic solidarity' and Scott McCloud's analysis of the 'gutter' reveal how meaning is produced through both sequential progression and the imaginative connections readers must make across and between panels. [3] These features decelerate the act of reading, demanding sustained attention and fostering an active, embodied engagement with narrative. This sense of slowness manifests not only in dense, information-rich pages that demand careful parsing, but also in minimalist, 'silent' sequences that invite readers to pause and reflect. [4] More recently, an interest in the materiality of comics has emerged, with scholars such as Ian Hague examining the 'objectness' of comics – the tactile textures of printed pages, the weight and feel of the book, and the sensory experience of reading.[5] This interest in materiality foregrounds how the physical form of comics, as well as our interaction with comics in digital media, shapes the rhythms of reading and intensifies readers' temporal and spatial engagement with narrative.

In this study, I consider the formal and material reflexivity in comics as a kind of 'slowness' that draws attention to the spaces, rhythms, and temporal disruptions emerging from extractive practices and within resource worlds. There are many ways that comics artists can surprise or intrigue readers through the manipulation of form. The distinction between 'tabular' (synoptic) and 'linear' (sequential) reading is often applied to the study of comics, outlining how readers negotiate ways of 'reading' or 'seeing' different modes and forms within the composition.[6] As readers negotiate these modalities and semiotic layers, slowness can involve both literal pauses and, following Caracciolo, a 'thickening of attention' – an immersive engagement that intensifies perception rather than simply extending time. [7] Karin Kukkonen makes a distinction between 'discourse speed' (the pace at which a story is told and experienced) and 'storyworld speed' (the pacing of events within the narrative), describing how authors represent, modulate, and invite reflection on the temporal experiences of characters. [8] At the same time, slowness is also embodied in the craft of comics: as objects that require slow, deliberate labour in their creation, they invite us to adopt a 'slow ontology' – a more reflective, embodied mode of understanding the world. [9]

Through their distinct engagements with Canadian resource extraction, Joe Sacco's *Paying the Land* (2020) and Kate Beaton's *Ducks* (2022) illuminate the social, environmental, and personal consequences of extractive industries. My analysis reads for formal and perceptual slowness in these texts, examining how they engage with time and temporality, and how they invite reflection on their own status as products of slow research and creative inquiry. [10] While both texts address the ethical and temporal complexities of resource extraction, they do so through distinct genres and through distinct ethical and affective strategies: Sacco's text operates within the traditions of comics journalism and documentary, providing an investigative, outward-looking account, while Beaton's graphic memoir offers a personal, autobiographical perspective. These differing modes shape how each work invites readers to reflect on the lived realities, ambiguities, and consequences of extraction and energy production, while also rendering visible histories and practices that remain largely unseen in contemporary media.

Disrupted temporalities in *Paying the Land*

In *Paying the Land*, Joe Sacco illustrates the entanglements of resource extraction, colonial history, and indigenous life in Canada's Northwest Territories. Focusing on Tulita, a Dene First Nations community, Sacco's episodic narrative moves through a series of interviews with elders, activists, and community leaders, mapping complex negotiations about land, livelihood, and survival. While the text documents the material impacts of mining, deforestation, and fracking, it also stages the affective and ethical ambivalence of communities caught between economic necessity and histories of dispossession. By layering scenes from the past and present, and foregrounding knowledge as mediated through spoken word and situated interactions, Sacco provides a way to apprehend the disruptive social effects of capitalist and colonial processes. Through interviews, historical flashbacks, and re-creations, *Paying the Land* invites readers to reflect on the intractable problem of resource development in the North and to experience the temporal and spatial disruptions wrought by historical change. In the following discussion, I examine *Paying the Land* in terms of how it unsettles linear, progressivist narratives of extraction by staging time as multiple, disrupted, and unresolved, inviting readers to experience both the violence and the endurance of alternative temporalities.

Sacco's graphic narratives have been acclaimed for pioneering 'comics journalism,' a genre that merges investigative reporting with comics art to document real-world events and illuminate the historical and social forces behind political violence. One of the earliest scholarly engagements with Sacco's work came from Edward Said, who in his Preface to *Palestine*

(2001) identified comics as uniquely suited to rendering complex political conflicts vividly and effectively. 'Certainly his images are more graphic than anything you can either read or see on television,' Said wrote, underscoring comics' visual immediacy and emotional resonance. [11] In later criticism, Hillary Chute emphasises Sacco's narrative disruptions, noting how the interplay of visual and textual elements creates pauses and rhythms that compel readers to engage with ethically charged subject matter. In *Disaster Drawn*, Chute shows that Sacco's work, and other documentary comics, provoke reflexive readings of difficult topics, as readers negotiate modes of witnessing historical atrocities. She argues that such pauses in reading can elicit ethical reflection, as comics 'give shape to lost histories and bodies', offering 'a new way of seeing'. [12]

Paying the Land builds on this tradition through a fragmented structure that draws attention to multiple viewpoints and sightlines. My particular focus here is on Sacco's representation of time: the juxtaposition of past and present, the sense of time as fragmented and disrupted, and the attention to historical processes operating below the surface – how histories are felt, experienced, and embodied. In the opening section, Sacco establishes the theme of temporality by depicting pre-colonial life in terms of cyclical temporality, relational learning, and dwelling within a resource world structured by reciprocity and 'paying back'. *Paying the Land* opens with a memory of nomadic life in Canada's remote north, as narrated by a Native elder. The scenes that are described by narrator, and artistically re-created through Sacco's drawings, focus on his early memories of learning how to contribute and find a meaningful and useful place in the circle of community: learning from others, from the land, and from the animals. In describing his childhood, readers recognise the appearance of some Western material, technology and culture – tools, cutlery, Christian weddings – but life is mostly described in bare terms: hunting, sometimes going hungry, and often contending with harsh weather conditions. In the opening section, 'You Find Yourself in the Circle,' Sacco abandons conventional panel borders, opting instead for full-page bleeds where captions blend seamlessly with the landscape. This formal choice visually emphasises how indigenous narratives and ecological interrelations resist the linear, extractivist logic imposed by colonial infrastructures (Figure 1).

Critics of comics have long made the distinction between 'tabular' versus 'linear' forms of reading, described by Jan Baetens as a tension between the 'sequential' and the 'synoptical': 'while linear, reading corresponds to a sequential temporality – following a successive flow of panels, strips, pages – a tabular reading, refers to a spatial mode. The reader takes the page at once, as a whole, and then make connections them in a synoptic way.'[13] Tabular reading, therefore, emphasises the simultaneous, spatial arrangement of panels on a page, allowing the reader to perceive the visual,

Figure 1. Joe Sacco, *Paying the Land*. p. 5.

textual, and compositional relationships holistically, while linear reading follows the sequential progression of panels, guiding the reader through a more directed narrative flow. Sacco's manipulation of tabular and linear reading modes unsettles narrative tempo, embedding storytelling within the cyclical, immanent rhythms of landscape itself – thereby enacting, at the level of form, the social bonds that precede and resist extractive practices. This effort to generate an aesthetic that captures the experience of an earlier time, can be interpreted in terms of 'dwelling in place', a notion that Theresa S. Smith and Jill M. Fiore describe in terms of locating multiple points of agency within the land. In their discussion of indigenous forms of

storytelling, they describe dwelling as contrasting and resisting colonialist notions of mobility that configure the land as an inert backdrop:

> Attuned to immanence, cyclical time, and a compelling sense of place, American Indian myths tell stories of people, human and otherwise, who do not travel toward eventual meaning but who dwell in and move through an inherently meaningful arena. The explorations described in myth are inseparable from the landscape that acts as a kind of metanarrative itself.[14]

For Smith and Fiore, the notion of 'dwelling' stands in opposition to 'a larger contemporary North American malaise permeating a mobile society', one that 'moves through and consumes land as resource'.[15] The idea, therefore, of not-travelling towards meaning, of resisting the impulse towards mobility and another horizon of experience, relates to a way of narrating and telling stories as part of the geographical terrain, and of being attentive to the stories that emerge or that are already present within, and around, the land itself.

As Sacco's text develops, we are introduced to a series of temporal shifts that portray and re-create episodes of the past that are narrated by the people he interviews. Through these interviews and historical explications, Sacco focuses on painful moments in history, including the history of Canadian residential schools and how the trauma of this experience resonates through history. One of Sacco's interviewees recalls how he was forced on to an aircraft, taken away from his family and placed into a residential school at the age of eight where he suffered from physical abuse and the psychological effects of being indoctrinated into moral and religious belief system that was largely foreign to him. This act of removing children from the community, part of a larger project of settler colonialism, can be read as another kind of extraction, a forceable removal of the indigenous body as a resource to be harnessed and tamed. These associations cast our attention to the ways in which colonialist acts of dispossession rely on a view of indigenous people as both passive and inert, as objects to be appropriated or collected.[16] Notably, while drawing our attention to this history, Sacco also reveals how the colonial project was reliant on a patriarchal social system where poor and middle class young white women, mostly French Canadian, were transported to the remote Canadian north and expected to live out their entire lives in these areas, further illustrating how the larger economic and cultural process of colonialism created other stories of displacement and alienation, even within the colonial structure itself.

Dominic Davies's discussion of *Paying the Land* positions these colonial acts within a context of capitalistic infrastructural expansion and an unfolding epoch of the Capitaloscene. He writes, 'Sacco draws infrastructure as a deeply historical form that infiltrates the web of life with relations of accumulation – relations that nonetheless are also contested by the Dene's contrasting relations of environmental stewardship, reciprocity, and care'.[17] For

Davies, comics engage with infrastructure from contrasting viewpoints, and in relation to longer histories, as the 'lines' on the comics page can be read as reflections of both infrastructural, terrestrial, and textual divisions:

> If infrastructure is the physical manifestation of capital's long-term restructuring of the environment, then comics too have registered this restructuring, not only in their content, but in the historicity of their form … Where textual forms like the novel are mostly confined to the cause-and-effect sequencing of linear syntax, the graphic novel has a scalar agility that allows it to move between terrestrial and cartographic viewpoints, drawing complex infrastructural arrangements into view.[18]

Davies's critique reveals how the form of comics provides an apt form through which to depict that role of capitalism and its instantiation as an 'epoch' of infrastructural development. The 'scalar agility' of the graphic narrative form (to use Davies's term) is able to represent the complex and implicated history in non-linear terms and from multiple perspectives.

However, while lines on the comics page may symbolise infrastructure – roads, pipelines, and capitalistic expansion – they also register the fragmentary, conflicted, and affective dimensions of historical experience and the slow, ambivalent process of reckoning with political and social complexity.[19] *Paying the Land* lays bare the complexity of contemporary problems in the North – domestic abuse, addiction, suicide – while also highlighting the contested visions for building a more sustainable and just future. Sacco's narrative demonstrates that these issues cannot be fully explained by reference to colonialism, capitalism, or extractivism alone; rather, they are entangled with local histories, cultural change, and ongoing negotiations of meaning and value. For example, while outlining the dark history Christian religious interventions in the North, Sacco also depicts its ongoing relevance and meaning today. As one interviewee, Dolphis, observes: 'because Christianity has existed in the northwest territories for a long time, and whatever it's problematic history here, it is now entangled with Dene tradition'.[20] The same is true for energy infrastructure: Sacco depicts oil and gas as sources of both disruption and dependency, noting that many Dene leaders support resource development while negotiating for more equitable partnerships, land rights, and economic benefits within existing frameworks.

While these events and viewpoints are staged through interviews, and left unresolved, Sacco himself is embedded within history, as a part of a longer process of colonial knowledge production in the North. Importantly, Sacco reveals himself as a reflexive narrator, a figure whose presence actively mediates our understanding of the issues and historical events. In a telling sequence, he describes his conversation with an anthropologist who is living and conducting research in the region. Sacco expresses his dismay at having to pay cash to his interviewees as compensation for their time:

'generally speaking what has been christened "traditional knowledge" is the province of the elders who gladly would pass it along to the young, but he might take a different tack with outsiders that come poking around with their anthropology sticks'.[21] Drawing attention to his own invested position as a researcher, Sacco offers an image of oil extraction imposed on the human mind (Figure 2). He writes, 'after all what's the difference between me and the oil company? We've both come here to extract something'.[22]

By drawing attention to his own positionality in relation to a long history of extraction, Sacco foregrounds the ethical complexity of documenting Indigenous knowledge and histories, a complexity that culminates in his exploration of ecological responsibility at the Giant Mine in Yellowknife, where industrialised gold mining has left a legacy of toxic waste. The remediation strategy for the site – burying hundreds of thousands of tons of arsenic trioxide in underground chambers, kept frozen by thermal siphons – is itself an uneasy negotiation with deep time: the technology is only guaranteed for

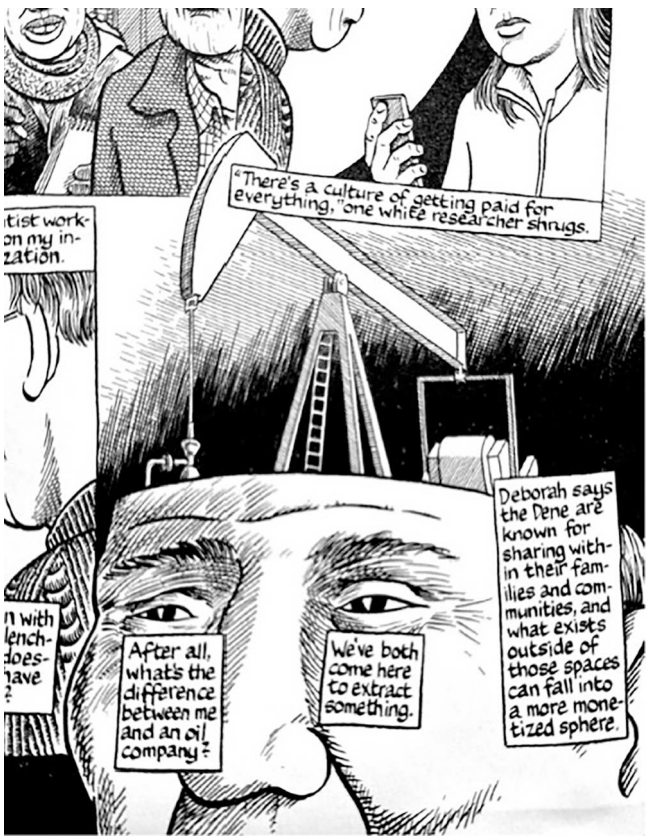

Figure 2. Joe Sacco, *Paying the Land*. p. 107.

about a century, leaving the poisonous material as a threat for future generations to confront. Sacco's descent into the mine's subterranean darkness, surrounded by ancient rock and the looming presence of industrial harm, literalises the encounter with geological time scales and the temporal disruptions of extraction. When Sacco asks whether the system might be upgraded in the future, he is told simply that the future generation would need to 'make a decision about whether or not to continue'.[23] The episode concludes with Sacco's return to the surface, still burdened by unanswered questions – not only about the Indigenous communities he has come to document, but about the worldview that enables such extraction in the first place: 'what is the worldview of the people who mumble no thanks, no prayers / who take what they want from the land / and pay it back with arsenic?'. [24] In this way, *Paying the Land* confronts readers with the ethical and temporal horizons of extraction – linking personal, historical, and geological timescales in a narrative that resists closure.

Paying the Land ultimately resists any singular narrative of extraction or infrastructural violence, as either a process of capitalistic or colonial expansion. By engaging readers with a multiplicity of viewpoints that are depicted through an assemblage of forms, structures, and frames, Sacco's comic, unsettles totalising historical accounts by foregrounding the messiness of lived time. Through juxtaposed timelines, and foregrounding contrasting temporalities, *Paying the Land* makes visible not only the violence of extraction, but also the endurance of other temporalities and ways of relating to land. As Sacco's reflexive presence as narrator further complicates any easy binary between witness and participant, outsider and insider, the text leaves readers with unresolved questions about complicity, responsibility – inviting us to pause with uncertainty rather than resolve it.

Autographics, attachment, and framing extraction in *Ducks*

While Sacco's *Paying the Land* employs a documentary, dialogic mode of comics reportage – foregrounding multiple viewpoints and contrasting discourses – Kate Beaton's *Ducks* turns inward, centreing on the intimate, everyday temporality of autobiographical experience within the oil sands. *Ducks: Two Years in the Oil Sands* (2022) recounts Beaton's time working in Alberta's oil sands – one of the world's largest industrial sites and a locus of both economic opportunity and environmental devastation. While the oil sands are a major economic powerhouse, they have also drawn criticism for their ecological impacts: deforestation, water pollution, greenhouse gas emissions, and land degradation. Beaton's graphic narrative engages with the environmental consequences of resource extraction by framing them through the subjective lens of her own journey as an indebted student from Eastern Canada navigating the isolating, male-dominated world of

the oil sands in order to pay off her loans. The comics form here is more than a vehicle for memoir; it becomes a method for exploring how identity is shaped within, and by, extractive environments. Crucially, the form's visual pacing enables a kind of narrative 'slowness': elongated sequences, silent panels, and careful attention to gesture and environment slow the reader's progress and invite reflection on the layered, everyday experiences of working within the extractive zone.

Discussions of autobiographical comics are well established and have been approached from a variety of critical perspectives over the past few decades. Gillian Whitlock's seminal work on autographics highlights how autobiographical comics use drawn avatars to navigate memory, identity, and the embodied experience of life writing, while she and Anna Poletti underscore the constructed nature of these works as 'life narrative fabricated in and through drawing and design using various technologies, modes, and materials.' [25] Elizabeth El Refaie, in turn, draws attention to the 'distinct formal resources and sociocultural associations' that make autobiographical comics particularly innovative, noting their roots in the subversive, irreverent comix of the 1960s and '70s.[26] Frederik Byrn Køhlert has argued that graphic autobiographies often engage with dominant visual traditions and can address issues of embodiment, memory, and social representation in unexpected ways. As Køhlert observes, these works frequently maintain 'an implicit conversation with an extended history of, for example, misogynist, racist, or ableist visual traditions that artists working in the form must contend with in various ways'.[27]

While much of this scholarship highlights the capacity of autographics to address trauma or marginalised experience, these insights also illuminate the form's ability to represent more ambiguous negotiations of selfhood, complicity, and displacement. It is in this vein that Beaton's *Ducks* can be situated: not as a narrative of conventional trauma, but as a nuanced exploration of what it means to be implicated – economically, ethically, and emotionally – within an environment shaped by harm and uncertainty. As a form that deploys an array of visual and verbal resources, *Ducks* becomes self-reflexive: a work of labour that comments on energy production more broadly, and by extension, its own material status as a cultural product. By harnessing the unique affordances of comics – fragmentation, the ability to slow, linger, and juxtapose – *Ducks* brings into focus the intimate textures of inhabiting and being a part of the extractive processes that drive modern energy production.

Through its layout and formal features, *Ducks* provides a sense of extractive operations, not only in terms of how they appear in geographical or spatial terms but how they are felt on an emotional level. Most pages in *Ducks* follow a consistent three-tier layout, with evenly spaced gutters and regularly alternating arrangements of six, seven, or nine panels – a format

that reflects the functionality and symmetry of industrial operations while producing a visual rhythm evocative of monotonous, workaday routines. This repetitive structure not only mirrors the routines of industrial labour but also enacts a form of narrative slowness, compelling readers to linger with the everyday realities of displacement rather than moving quickly toward resolution. Within these repetitive structures, workers themselves are physically drained and emotionally tapped, becoming depressed, troubled, or turning to substance abuse. Much of the action in the graphic narrative take place in long, blocky housing units and minimalist office spaces that are devoid of decoration or personal character. Resembling other modern non-places, such as airports or corporate office parks, *Ducks* shows the world in the oil sands as orderly yet masking underlying emotional tensions and interpersonal disconnections.

Beaton's autobiographical avatar navigates through the story as a stranger in a strange land, offering readers an outsider's view of oil operations from the perspective of a young, educated woman with a newly minted Arts degree. As an eager and naïve new employee who is full of questions, Beaton's probes into life within the industrial environment, revealing various forms of disfunction that lie beneath the surface. In a memorable exchange, Beaton asks her supervisor the seemingly innocuous question, 'Leon? Is this a … nice place to work?' Leon's rough reply exemplifies the harsh managerial culture that values economic return over all other considerations: 'What kind of question is that? You're here and you make money, or fuck up and get fired. Then I have to train some other dumb fuck from butthole nowhere' – captures the affective expectations within the camp.[28] Elsewhere, small talk between employees reveals a sense of troubled and displaced social identities. At one point Beaton asks her coworker, 'Ambrose – were you a fisherman before?,' [29] with his reply underscoring a persistent incongruity: 'I'm still a fisherman. I'm just here.' [30] Or later, Beaton herself exclaims, 'I don't have a life here or anywhere else at this point!'. [31]

On a visual level, the workers in oilfields wear the same protective equipment replete with hardhats and glasses, yet the power relations that emerge between them is clearly asymmetrical. Throughout, Beaton describes being observed or judged by men, or how she becomes a spectacle for the male gaze, with men often lining up at her work counter to view her or make some form of sexual advance. While Beaton's recounts most of these episodes as annoyances, she is eventually victim of a more serious act of sexual aggression, as she experiences date rape at a party. This incident is clearly traumatic, made worse by her inability to speak about the incident openly. Elsewhere in the text, the theme of sexual exploitation is further reinforced when Beaton recounts her experience visiting a strip club with male co-workers, further revealing how women's bodies become

commodified and degraded into visual spectacles within a normalised culture of disposable transient labour.

Ducks reveals how these forms of watching and gazing are performed and normalised within the workplace culture, but while Beaton is shown to be the object of desire, she also projects her own gaze, as an artist, social observer, and as a subject with her own attachments and curiosities. Figure 3 depicts Beaton observing an enormous tractor during a tour of a new work facility. Framed dramatically and drawn with exaggerated perspective, the tractor visually dominates the page, emphasising its immense size, power, and the awe it evokes. Although the discourse speed, the time required to read the page, is relatively brief, readers experience a palpable pause, a narrative slowing that mirrors Beaton's astonishment and introspection within the

Figure 3. From *Ducks: Two Years in the Oil Sands*, p. 105. Copyright Kate Beaton. Used with permission from Drawn & Quarterly.

storyworld. On one hand, the tractor explicitly represents danger: `earlier in the narrative, Beaton learns of a horrific accident in which a pickup truck – with the driver inside – was crushed by a similar vehicle. Yet, on the other hand, the tractor symbolises economic opportunity and social mobility. Upon viewing the tractor, Beaton's guide casually remarks that a woman previously drove one of these 'monsters', adding that 'good money' can be made in such work.[32]

In *Ducks* bodies, machinery, and objects have meaning within the larger functioning of the organisation, not just in terms of their functionality, but as they represent desires, fantasies, and emotional bonds. In a seminal study of the comics form, Scott McCloud illustrates how abstract or cartoonish images elicit reader engagement and empathy while more realistic renderings can convey otherness and distance. 'Humans,' writes McCloud, 'are a self-centered race' that 'assign identities and emotions where none exist.'[33] In the case of the cartoon, a highly abstract and universal image, people are compelled to see themselves: 'The cartoon is a vacuum into which our identity and awareness are pulled … an empty shell that we inhabit which enables us to travel in another realm. We don't just observe the cartoon, we become it!'.[34] In terms of its readerly engagement, therefore, we might think of a comic as a form that involves negotiation and reciprocal processes of identification and meaning-making. As Beaton's text draws readers into the storyworld, we feel how life operates within the industrial setting, where workers deal with psychological and social displacements while also maintaining ambivalent relationships with the structures and operations that sustain their livelihoods.

In this sense, *Ducks* is not merely a testimony to the psychic and ecological toll of extractive capitalism, but a meditation on the affective infrastructures that undergird industrial modernity. Through repetitive panel structures and layouts, Beaton visually indexes the routinised temporality of camp life – a rhythm of monotony, exhaustion, and suspended desire. Yet, within this apparent regularity, the narrative continually surfaces moments of rupture: the persistent sense of displacement among workers, the gendered violence and surveillance that structure everyday interactions, and the fleeting glimpses of awe or longing that attach even to the machinery of extraction itself. Here, Brian Larkin's exploration of the 'poetics' of infrastructure becomes especially salient:

> Infrastructures … exist as forms separate from their purely technical functioning, and they need to be analyzed as concrete semiotic and aesthetic vehicles oriented to addressees. They emerge out of and store within them forms of desire and fantasy and can take on fetish-like aspects that sometimes can be wholly autonomous from their technical function. Focusing on the issue of form, or the poetics of infrastructure, allows us to understand how the political can be constituted through different means. [35]

In foregrounding these affective attachments, attachments that bind subjects to sites of exploitation, but also to each other, *Ducks* renders these built environments as simultaneously objects of fantasy and vehicles for the circulation of desire and ambivalence. This critical orientation is not intended to aestheticize or neutralise the violence of extraction, but to account for the complex ways in which subjects are situated within, and sometimes ensnared, by the forms, rhythms, and affects of these landscapes.

While Beaton's visual landscapes foreground the ecological devastation wrought by resource operations, *Ducks* also interrogates the digital and discursive infrastructures that organise visibility and knowledge. In one sequence, Beaton and a friend watch online videos posted by Indigenous activists, exposing the toxic fallout and rising cancer rates linked to the oil sands. The act is shadowed by anxiety over company surveillance and anticipated censorship – a reminder of the infrastructural management of information and the strategic obfuscation of harm. Recalling a conversation with archaeology students employed by oil companies to 'investigate local sites in case there is anything important there before they build', Beaton juxtaposes the phrase 'anything important' with the image of an Indigenous activist, underscoring the pervasive erasure and silencing of Indigenous claims. [36] Troubled by her own complicity in these systems of denial, she confesses: 'Going to Alberta was like going to the moon. It was just so far beyond. Now I can't extract myself from having come'.[37]

The sense of violence in *Ducks* is not limited to human experience. Beaton's recurring encounters with animals – most notably a three-legged fox, likely maimed on site, and the episode of ducks trapped in toxic tailings ponds – extend the narrative's register of harm to the more-than-human world. Her emotional outburst towards the fox, an attempt to save it by frightening it away, reads as both an act of care and an anguished recognition of her own implication in the violence of extraction. These animal presences remind us of the broader collateral damage of industrial operations, mirroring Beaton's own sense of harm and entanglement. In this way, *Ducks* suggests that the harms of extraction are not only social or psychological, but ecological and corporeal, implicating all forms of life that come into contact with these landscapes.

By decelerating the reader's encounter with these moments, *Ducks* enacts a critique of the velocity and seductive allure of extractive capitalism itself. The graphic narrative renders industrial structures as both alienating and affectively charged, inviting readers to sense the desires, attachments, and forms of endurance that circulate within these non-places. Even as the extractive economy imposes systems of non-reciprocity and temporal acceleration, *Ducks* foregrounds its own materiality as a product of slow, deliberate labour – a counter-rhythm to the disposability of extractive culture. By

drawing us into the affective atmospheres of extraction, Beaton's narrative compels us to recognise our own implication in these worldly circuits.

Seeing energy otherwise

Theorists in the energy humanities have increasingly approached energy not merely as a material resource or commodity, but as a historically contingent, socio-material process that permeates political, cultural, and affective life. For many, energy appears as an abstracted commodity – delivered 'out of nowhere,' through infrastructures that remain largely invisible or managed elsewhere. Yet, as the field of energy geography insists, a 'whole systems' perspective reveals the entanglements of resource extraction, waste production, and consumption, mapping extractive zones, ecological sacrifice areas, and urban centres as interconnected nodes within global circuits of energy.[38]

As Imre Szeman and Dominic Boyer argue, the pervasive in/visibility of energy and its infrastructures constitutes a persistent epistemological problem: 'not only energy in general, but also fossil fuels in particular have been surprisingly hard to figure – narratively, visually, conceptually – as a central element of the modern'. Despite their omnipresence, fossil fuels remain 'hidden in plain sight/site.'[39] This essay has argued that the comics form is uniquely equipped to address this epistemological opacity, rendering the lived realities of resource peripheries through a medium that is subjective, reflexive, and layered. There is no epistemological certainty with comics; instead, they foreground their own processes of mediation, framing, and the situatedness of knowledge. In this sense, comics may provide an intervention, not by solving the problem of energy in/visibility, but by opening up spaces for critical reflection and recognition, however provisional, of the connections between resource frontiers and the everyday.

In bringing Sacco's investigative, reflexive approach into dialogue with Beaton's intimate, autobiographical perspective, this essay has highlighted the potential of comics to engage with the ethical, temporal, and affective complexities of resource extraction. Sacco's *Paying the Land* unsettles linear narratives of extraction by juxtaposing disrupted temporalities, Indigenous knowledge systems, and colonial histories, creating a fragmented and layered narrative that resists easy resolution. Through his reflexive presence as narrator and his attention to the embodied and historical effects of extraction, Sacco invites readers to grapple with the messiness of lived time and the enduring entanglements of colonialism, capitalism, and environmental harm. Beaton's *Ducks*, by contrast, brings the reader inside the affective infrastructures of extraction through a deeply personal lens, where repetitive panel structures and narrative slowness evoke the monotony, displacement, and ambivalence of camp life. Together, these works demonstrate how comics can render visible not only the material and

ecological violence of extraction but also the ethical and emotional entanglements that bind individuals and communities to these systems. By harnessing the unique affordances of the medium – its capacity to fragment and juxtapose timelines, slow the reader's experience, and foreground the situatedness of knowledge – Sacco and Beaton challenge us to inhabit the complexities of complicity, responsibility, and endurance within extractive economies. In doing so, their works compel us to reconsider the ethical, environmental, and emotional stakes of extraction and its sustained impact on the rhythms of everyday life.

Notes

1. Ajay Singh Chaudhary theorises extractive practices as circuits that operate across national and social boundaries. Chaudhary writes, 'At every "node" along such a circuit, "inputs" – ecological, political, social, individual – are extracted and "exhausted." The circuit, like capital, crosses boundaries without entirely obliterating them, and, similarly, connects a vast potential political subject across disparate lines – Global North and South, gender, class, race, nationality, religion, and sexuality.'; The Extractive Circuit', The Baffler, no. 60, November 2021, https://thebaffler.com/salvos/the-extractive-circuit-singh-chaudhary [Date accessed: 14 Jan 2025]. For a fascinating discussion on the pervasive disruptions of extractivism on individual lives, see also Diletta De Cristofaro (2024) 'How do you sleep at night knowing all this?': Climate breakdown, sleep, and extractive capitalism in contemporary literature and culture, *Textual Practice*, 38, p. 10.
2. R. Nixon, *Slow Violence and the Environmentalism of the Poor* (Harvard University Press, 2011), p. 2.
3. Thierry Groensteen's concept of 'iconic solidarity' describes how meaning in comics arises not only from the sequence of panels but also from the 'braiding' of motifs, images, and visual themes that recur or echo across the page or the entire work. This system encourages readers to navigate both linear and non-linear connections, assembling meaning through an active, participatory process (T. Groensteen, *The System of Comics* (University Press of Mississippi, 2007)). Scott McCloud, likewise, highlights the interpretive labor required in the gutter – the blank space between panels – where the reader imaginatively constructs continuity and becomes, as he puts it, 'a silent accomplice' in meaning-making (*Understanding Comics: The Invisible Art*. New York: Harper Perennial, 1994, p. 68).
4. For a discussion of silent comics and their unique narrative techniques, see Barbara Postema, 'Silent Comics', in Frank Bramlett, Roy T. Cook, and Aaron Meskin (eds), *The Routledge Companion to Comics*, (Routledge, 2016), pp. 201–208. On the ways comics can evoke temporal duration, see also Jan Baetens and Caroline Pylyser, 'Comics and Time', in *The Routledge Companion to Comics*, pp. 303–10.
5. For a comprehensive account of comics' materiality and 'objectness', see Hague, I. *Comics and the Senses: A Multisensory Approach to Comics and Graphic Novels* (Routledge, 2014). Aaron Kashtan extends this discussion of materiality to include an extended account of digital comics, arguing that 'it

is impossible to dissociate the semiotic content of the text from its physical form, or even to imagine the two as separate' (*Between Pen and Pixel: Comics, Materiality, and the Book of the Future*. The Ohio State University Press, 2018, p. 14).

6. For a useful overview of the effects of composition, form, and speed in comics see J. Baetens, & C. Pylyser, 'Comics and time', In *The Routledge companion to comics* (Routledge, 2016), pp. 303–10; H. Frey & J. Baetens, *The Graphic Novel: An Introduction* (2015).
7. Caracciolo argues that narrative deceleration in comics and other forms can prompt readers to rethink the relationship between humans and the non-human world, drawing on work by Grusin and Bennett to frame this in terms of materiality and agency. See: Marco Caracciolo, *Slow Narrative: The Temporality of Ethical Engagement* (University of Nebraska Press, 2022), esp. ch. 1.
8. Karin Kukkonen, 'The Speed of Plot: Narrative Acceleration and Deceleration', in Marco Caracciolo and Ella Mingazova (eds), *Slow Narrative across Media* (Ohio State University Press, 2024), pp. 17–34. Kukkonen describes storyworld speed as 'The impression of speed in the storyworld that arises from embodied language' (p. 18).
9. Ulmer proposes 'slow ontology' as a methodological and philosophical intervention in academic practice –shifting the focus from merely slowing productivity to reimagining the very mode of scholarly being. Drawing inspiration from global 'Slow' movements (e.g., Slow Food, Slow Cities), Ulmer suggests that slow ontology invites researchers to engage writing as a site of creative and material inquiry, foregrounding quality and attentiveness over speed and output. See: J. B. Ulmer, 'Writing Slow Ontology', *Qualitative Inquiry* 23, no. 3 (2016): 201–11.see also Glenn Adamson, *The Invention of Craft* (2013); Arden Reed, *Slow Art: The Experience of Looking, Sacred Images to James Turrell* (2017).
10. Comics artist Chris Ware once mused on the contrast between the time spent creating and consuming comics, stating, 'there is something interesting about sitting at a table for a couple of decades working on a book that takes three or four hours to read'. While this dynamic exists in other media, such as film, comics uniquely lay bare the traces of their creation, emphasizing their labor-intensive, deliberate slowness. See Art21. (n.d.). *Chris Ware in 'Chicago' – Season 8* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=I2qQgFM66lw&t=388s
11. Edward Said. 'Homage to Joe Sacco'. Preface. *Palestine* (Seattle: Fantagraphics Books, 2001), p. iii.
12. H. L. Chute, *Disaster drawn: Visual witness, comics, and documentary form* (Harvard University Press, 2016), p. 38. See also Hillary Chute, 'Comics as Literature? Reading Graphic Narrative', *PMLA*, 123.2 (2008), pp. 452–65.
13. Jan Baetens, 'Turning the pages and going up and down: on Seth's *Clyde Fans*', in Marco Caracciolo and Ella Mingazova (eds). *Slow Narrative Across Media*, (Athens: The Ohio State Univ. 2024). Kindle. 112–13.
14. Theresa S. Smith and Jill M. Fiore. 'Landscape as Narrative, Narrative as Landscape.' *Studies in American Indian Literatures* 22.4 (2010): 58–80. p. 60.
15. Ibid., p. 82.
16. In a discussion of Canadian contemporary Indigenous writings, Moritz Ingwersen argues that contemporary authors engage with complicity

between settler colonialism and resource extraction through the systematic exploitation of Indigenous populations as they are imagined as commodifiable resources. See Ingwersen, 'Reclaiming Fossil Ghosts: Indigenous Resistance to Resource Extraction in Works by Warren Cariou, Cherie Dimaline, and Nathan Adler', *Canadian Literature*, 240 (2020), pp. 59–76.

17. D. Davies, Graphic Capitaloscenes: Drawing Infrastructure as Historical Form. *Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction*, *65*, no. 4 (2024), p. 686.
18. Ibid., p. 682.
19. Rather than viewing infrastructure solely as an instrument of capital or colonial expansion, some scholars have emphasized its affective and relational dimensions. Lauren Berlant, for example, defines infrastructure as 'another way of talking about mediation – but always as a material process of binding' (On the Inconvenience of Other People, Duke University Press, 2022, p. 22). A road, then, is not just a physical path but also an affective and conceptual link, shaping connections and experiences. Recent work in infrastructure studies highlights how infrastructures, while enabling capitalist or colonial projects, can also foster resistance or new social formations (see K. M. Rich, N. M. Rizzuto & S. Zieger, (Eds.), *The Aesthetic Life of Infrastructure: Race, Affect, Environment*, Northwestern University Press, 2022). For instance, Ramesh Mallipeddi's essay in this collection shows that colonial roads in plantation economies, even as they supported exploitation, also became routes for Black sociality and commerce.
20. Sacco, *Paying the Land*, p. 187.
21. Ibid., p. 107.
22. Ibid., p. 107.
23. Ibid., p. 248.
24. Ibid., p. 249.
25. G. Whitlock, 'Autographics: The Seeing "I" of the Comics'. *MFS Modern Fiction Studies*, 52, no. 4 (2006), pp. 965–79. G. Whitlock & A. Poletti, 'Self-Regarding Art', *Biography*, 31, no. 1 (2008), p. v.
26. E. El Refaie, *Autobiographical Comics: Life Writing in Pictures* (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2012), p. 7.
27. F. B. Køhlert, *Serial Selves: Identity and Representation in Autobiographical Comics* (New Brunswick: Rutgers University Press, 2019), p. 3.
28. Kate Beaton, *Ducks: Two Years in the Oil Sands* (Montreal: Drawn & Quarterly, 2022), p. 147.
29. Ibid., p. 113.
30. Ibid., p. 113.
31. Ibid., p. 133.
32. Ibid., p. 105.
33. McCloud, *Understanding Comics,* p. 32, p. 34.
34. Ibid. p. 36.
35. B. Larkin, The politics and poetics of infrastructure. *Annual review of anthropology*, *42* (2013), p. 329.
36. Beaton, *Ducks*, p. 362. Anthropologist Sara Ann Wylie theorizes this kind of systematic erasure as a form of institutionalized 'agnotology' – the deliberate production and maintenance of ignorance, doubt, or forgetting, particularly around the effects of extractive industries. While *Ducks* foregrounds moments of overt censorship (such as anticipated company surveillance of activist media), the more casual dismissal of Indigenous land claims by the

archaeology students exemplifies a quieter, more insidious agnotological logic. See Sara Ann Wylie, *Fractivism: Corporate Bodies and Chemical Bonds* (Durham: Duke Univ. Press, 2018).

37. Beaton, *Ducks*, p. 363.
38. For instance, see Jenkins, et al, 'Energy Justice: A Whole Systems Approach', *Queen's Political Review*, 2.2. 74–87. Here the authors describe an energy system approach as an energy chain from production, conversion, transmission, and distribution, through to energy consumption and waste. The authors also describe such systems as both physical and as social entities that represent complex human technology interactions.
39. I. Szeman & D. Boyer, (Eds.), *Energy humanities: An anthology* (JHU Press, 2017). p. 6.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).